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REVIEW ARTICLE

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Climate policy backlash: taming an unruly concept?

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ABSTRACT

Backlash is a growing concern among climate and environmental politics scholars. Abrupt negative pushback against climate and environmental policies, among both elites and mass publics, increasingly shapes the politics of policy action and societal transformation. Moreover, socio-political polarization, societal unrest, and geopolitical shocks may raise the chances of future policy backlash. However, the concept of backlash is used in fragmented and inconsistent ways, undermining its potential to distinguish and explain important political dynamics. We therefore ask: *How is the concept of climate policy backlash being employed in climate policy and politics literature, and with what consequences for its study and explanation?* We conduct a systematic critical review of literature related to climate policy backlash. We observe variation in analytical approaches (concerning forms of backlash, objects, subjective perceptions, and effects) and underlying explanations (backlash as reactionary political behavior, interest-based countermobilization, emancipatory political action, or 'ordinary' politics). We caution against taming the unruly concept of climate policy backlash. It is a complex and contradictory phenomenon with potential for both negative and positive effects on climate policy development that can politicize and depoliticize policy making, and reflect both extraordinary and ordinary politics simultaneously.

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Political backlash; public backlash; green backlash; backlash politics; policy conflict; greenlash

1. Introduction

Backlash to climate and/or environmental policy is a growing concern among scholars, policy-makers, and commentators. Strong negative pushback against climate-related policies and initiatives in many countries shape the politics of policy action and societal transformation. This challenges presumptions about public acceptance of ambitious policy, and casts doubt on the extent to which policy can be designed to overcome resistance and pushback (Patterson & Paterson, 2024). Mass publics and/or social groups may react against policy seen as too demanding (Patterson, 2023), unfairly allocating burdens (Driscoll, 2023), misaligned with public priorities, or overreaching government authority (Patashnik, 2019). While not always so (Hess & Renner, 2019; Schaller & Carius, 2019), right-wing populist policy agendas (whether channeled via populist or mainstream political parties) may oppose climate policy and seek to undermine wider policy support (Crowley, 2017; Lockwood, 2018; Paterson et al., 2024; Raymond, 2020). Broader geopolitical tensions and

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shocks as well as growing societal unrest and democratic malaise are also often thought to increase the likelihood of policy backlash. However, the concept of backlash is used in fragmented and inconsistent ways, undermining its potential to distinguish and explain important political dynamics.

Backlash refers to 'an abrupt and forceful negative reaction by a significant number of actors within a political community seeking to reverse a political development … [constituting] a volatile and largely unexpected pushback that can involve various actors (e.g. mass publics, political elites, organized interests)' (Patterson, 2023, p. 69). It names a specific phenomenon: a strong, potentially hostile negative reaction to a policy or political development, distinct from broader notions of policy contestation (where backlash is an extreme form) and policy change (as backlash is a sociopolitical reaction rather than a policy change process). Backlash is, therefore, also distinct from notions of strategic policy dismantling, rollback/repeal, and retrenchment, because it centers on an abrupt and often unexpected reaction against a policy via an eruption of discontent rather than longer-term policy dismantling by political elites (Patterson et al., 2025). Moreover, its effects on policy outputs and outcomes can vary, and may or may not include rollback/repeal and retrenchment (Patashnik, 2023). Importantly, backlash is not reducible to right-wing populism. An eruption of discontent may involve grievances triggered spontaneously through a shared sense of outrage, not necessarily (or only) mediated by populist elites and sentiments. Actors and coalitions involved may be more cross-cutting and situation-specific. Moreover, backlash could occur in any direction not just anti-progressive (Alter & Zürn, 2020; Patashnik, 2019), and against different types of policy action for different reasons, and thus needs to be seen in an open-ended way.

The concept of climate (and environmental) policy backlash is unruly because the underlying phenomenon is unruly. Backlash is situated at the interface of institutionalized politics (e.g. voting, political parties, policy making) and non-institutionalized politics (e.g. social discontent, mobilization). It can involve different actors and coalitions, multiple and disparate climate-related issues (e.g. climate policy, renewable energy infrastructure, but also fossil fuel development), and have varying effects on policy and politics. Consequently, how backlash manifests can also vary from case to case. This also means that it resists neat circumscription (e.g. using qualifiers like *voter* backlash, *industry* backlash, *farmer* backlash, or even *societal* backlash, …), which narrow what is likely to be more complex political dynamics in each case.[1] There is also a growing risk of concept stretching where any form of contestation or criticism is (unwarrantedly) labeled as backlash, backlash is taken as self-evident without careful delineation of the underlying phenomenon, or terms are specified differently than in previous work for no clear reason.[2] Furthermore, proliferating descriptive use of backlash without substantive engagement obscures the core issues, such as when the term is used merely as a warning ('there will be backlash unless … '), a managerial problem ('how can we avoid backlash?'), or just as a catchy term. Altogether, this creates fuzziness around backlash as an important concept in contemporary politics, requiring critical interrogation of current insights as a foundation for future work.

We therefore ask: *How is the concept of climate policy backlash being employed in climate policy and politics literature, and with what consequences for its study and explanation?* We aim to critically appraise the concept of climate policy backlash and its use by: (i) assessing variation in how it is studied, (ii) consolidating insights across fragmented lines of thinking, and (iii) stimulating constructive debate about the concept and its application. We conduct a systematic critical review of literature considering both explicit and implicit links to the concept. We observe variation in analytical approaches concerning forms of backlash, subjective perceptions, and policy and political

effects. We also observe different underlying explanations of backlash as reactionary political behavior, interest-based countermobilization, emancipatory political action, or 'ordinary' politics. Altogether, this suggests the need for further conceptual development not necessarily to develop a singular notion of climate policy backlash but to avoid siloes in emerging work.[3] A relational and contextual view is needed as a basis for comparison, focusing on socio-political processes and dynamics, rather than static, decontextualized, and/or methodology-driven analyses. We caution against trying to tame the unruly concept of climate policy backlash. It is a complex and contradictory phenomenon, with the potential to both negatively and positively affect climate policy, politicize and depoliticize policy making, and simultaneously reflect both extraordinary and ordinary politics.

2. Uptake of the concept of climate policy backlash

Work on backlash related to climate policy has grown over time. Backlash was sporadically studied in climate and environmental policy/politics before around 2019 yet interest has been growing rapidly since then (Figure 1). Climate policy backlash also intersects with other debates over opposition to climate policy, including anti-environmentalism, climate obstruction, social acceptance, just transition, public preferences, political economy, and right-wing populism. Growing empirical observations of contentious pre- and post-adoption experiences in climate policy now prompt new questions about climate policy backlash specifically, including how it can be studied and explained.

2.1. Emergence of climate policy backlash as an issue of concern

Concerns about climate policy backlash arise in the context of various related longstanding and more recent debates. One important antecedent is anti-environmentalism. This includes work on corporate efforts to undermine climate science (McCright & Dunlap, 2000; Oreskes & Conway,

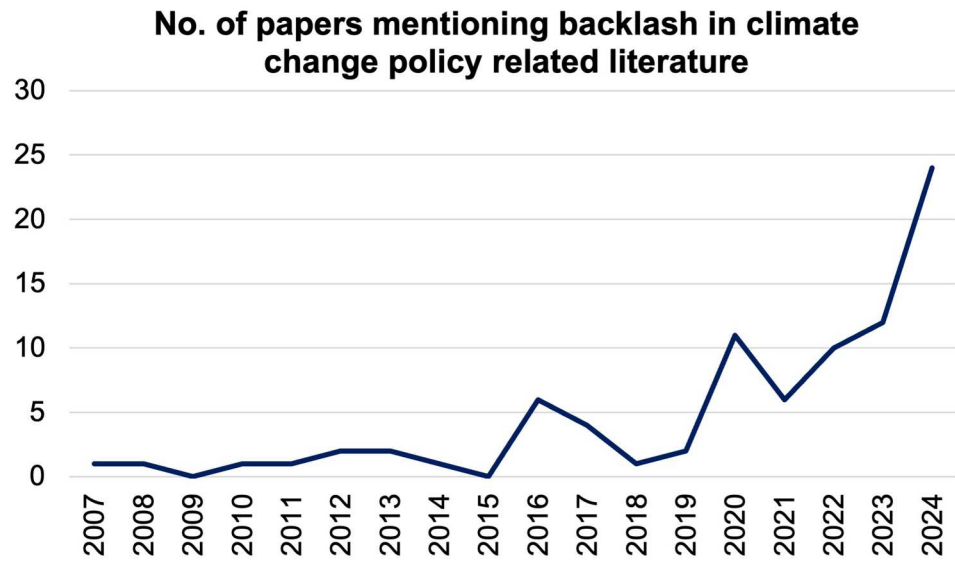


Figure 1. Uptake of papers using the term backlash related to climate change policy (identified through systematic search and screening explained in section 3).

2011) and foster wider distrust of government and 'hostility toward government regulation' (Oreskes & Conway, 2022), strategies used by governments to control policy responses (Young & Coutinho, 2013), and earlier backlash against climate science (Lahsen, 2008; Sarewitz, 2010). Related work on conservative counter-movements has extensively examined how think tanks, industry, business, and utilities, among others, mobilize to undermine climate policy efforts (Brulle, 2021, 2018; Downie, 2017; Jacques et al., 2008; McKie, 2021; Tindall et al., 2022). This can lead to 'non-decision-making' (McCright & Dunlap, 2010) and rollback of policies and regulations (Tindall et al., 2022), and even reflect defense of capitalist political order (McCright & Dunlap, 2011a; McKie, 2019).

Closely building on anti-environmentalism, a prominent contemporary focus on climate obstruction has now developed. This work examines the range of 'intentional actions and efforts to slow or block policies on climate change' (Brulle et al., 2024; Roberts et al., 2025). It considers a variety of actors including corporations, think tanks, foundations, funders, industry bodies, lobbyists, public relations and advertising firms, media, and governments, both individually and in coalitions (Brulle et al., 2024; Roberts et al., 2025). It also identifies strategies over multiple timeframes, including long-term strategies to shape research and promote certain worldviews, intermediate-term strategies to promote and/or delegitimate certain policies, and short-term strategies to lobby, mobilize citizens, and influence campaigns (Brulle et al., 2024). In this view, climate policy backlash may link to obstruction dynamics especially over short- to intermediate-timeframes. But climate policy backlash also requires distinct attention as it is often likely to arise through reactive or spontaneous mobilization of a broad base of social and political actors who are not necessarily obstructive per se, but who react in a particular moment under a particular set of conditions (Patterson et al., 2025).

Simultaneously, work on wider societal opposition to climate policy has developed from multiple angles. This includes, for example, the role of polarization (Coffé et al., 2025; McCright et al., 2016; McCright & Dunlap, 2011a), social identity (Daggett, 2018; McCright & Dunlap, 2011b; Weko, 2022), and cultural attributes (Brulle & Norgaard, 2019; Bulkeley et al., 2016; Laidley, 2013) in resistance to climate policy. From another angle, longstanding (Batel et al., 2013; McAdam & Boudet, 2012; Wüstenhagen et al., 2007) and recent (Stokes et al., 2023) work on social acceptance of energy infrastructure highlights the complex dynamics of opposition to specific interventions in specific places, often emphasizing how this can defy preconceived ideas about pro- and anti-climate action (e.g. Batel, 2018; Kati et al., 2021). From another angle again, extensive work on just transitions examines how the adverse consequences of climate policy for fossil fuel producing communities/regions, workers, and industries (Brown & Spiegel, 2019; Godinho, 2022; Newell & Mulvaney, 2013) can be addressed, suggesting risks of severe discontent and opposition otherwise.

Within this broader context, attention to climate policy backlash now arises along several lines. First, institutional political economy work highlights the potential for climate policy backlash due to the difficult politics of regulation (such as weak/diffuse support vs strong/concentrated opposition, and normalization of climate impacts undermining rationales for climate action) (Biber, 2008), and examines factors shaping climate policy adoption and repeal such as the interplay of political institutions and interests (Finnegan, 2022; Mildenberger, 2020), shifting incentives in energy transitions (Breetz et al., 2018), and the dynamics of political support for climate policy (Biber et al., 2017; Meckling et al., 2015). Second, survey-based work seeks to detect backlash in voting behavior (Colantone et al., 2023; e.g. Egli et al., 2022; Stutzmann, 2025) and assess the electoral implications of new forms of climate policy (Bolet et al., 2024), also linked to wider work

examining factors influencing public support for climate policy such as policy type and cost distribution (Bakaki & Bernauer, 2017; Bergquist et al., 2022; Carattini et al., 2019; Maestre-Andrés et al., 2019). Third, populism-focused work links climate policy backlash to right-wing populism (Bosetti et al., 2025; Paterson et al., 2024; Vihma et al., 2021), often building on wider studies of the links between right-wing populism and opposition to climate action (Lockwood, 2018; Lockwood & Lockwood, 2022).

Interest in climate policy backlash has been motivated by growing empirical observations of backlash and/or pushback. Early instances included backlash to automobile-related policies (Paterson, 2007), cap-and-trade climate policy (Skocpol, 2013), and provincial wind energy policy (Stokes, 2016). From around 2017 onwards, a growing litany of cases of climate policy rollback and dismantling (e.g. Bomberg, 2021; Crowley, 2017; Davidescu et al., 2018; Gürtler et al., 2019; Karapin, 2020a; Milhorance, 2022; O'Neill & Gibbs, 2020; Prontera, 2021; Raymond, 2020) and/or public protests against climate policy (e.g. Arning & Ziefle, 2020; Martin & Islar, 2021) began to be documented. More recently, prominent policies in Europe (Green Deal) (Bocquillon, 2024) and the United States (Inflation Reduction Act) (Patashnik, 2023) attract interest over their potential (or not) for backlash.

However, despite burgeoning attention to climate policy backlash, work remains highly fragmented. There is a pressing need to critically take stock of how the concept is being used, to help create connections between parallel lines of work, and to enable work to productively cumulate. Given the complexity of the phenomenon, doing so requires stepping back to consider core features.

2.2. Needs

Two key needs arise: (1) to interrogate the varying *analytical approaches* employed, and (2) to identify the *underlying explanations* put forward for why and how backlash arises.

Considering analytical approaches to climate policy backlash is needed because different approaches are being taken. Crucially, climate policy backlash cuts across institutionalized politics (e.g. policy processes, party politics, voting) and non-institutionalized politics (e.g. social movements and mobilization, wider discontent), which often remain separate (Hacker & Pierson, 2014, p. 650; McAdam & Tarrow, 2010; Tarrow, 2022). Different *forms* of backlash thus need to be considered, which may involve different combinations of actors. Different *objects* triggering backlash may also be involved, including both policies and infrastructure, taking a broad view of what constitutes climate-related policy (Corbera et al., 2019). *Subjective perceptions* among actors are also important. Perceptions and meanings of policy action are generated interactively throughout a policy process (Stone, 2012), and may change when specific proposals become objects of heated debate[4] and resonate with wider societal grievances. What is considered effective, fair, or costly (e.g. Bergquist et al., 2022; Drews & van den Bergh, 2016) is also not entirely objective nor time-invariant.[5] The *effects* of backlash may also vary, both on policy (e.g. rollback/reversal, weakening, no change, strengthening) and wider politics (e.g. loss of proponents' credibility, undermining a policy agenda). While other effects could also occur (e.g. on public opinion, media coverage, and discourse), we focus on a subset most likely directly policy-relevant and discernable in the literature studied.

Attention to underlying explanations of why and how climate policy backlash occurs is also important. Wider literature often portrays backlash as *reactionary political behavior* (e.g. defending power relations (Mansbridge & Shames, 2008) or conservative cultural values (Norris & Inglehart,

2019)), or as *interest-based counter-mobilization* among actors and coalitions threatened by policy change (for economic and/or cultural reasons) (Jones et al., 2019; Patashnik, 2023). Yet, others, such as scholars of agonistic or critical politics, could assert that backlash is an *emancipatory political action* where overlooked or marginalized actors lash back to make themselves heard. Others may suggest more prosaically that backlash is part of the '*ordinary*' *politics* of struggles over policy and societal change (Alexander, 2019). Elucidating underlying explanations being proposed is important to understand current views and tendencies.

3. Methodology

We conducted a systematic review of published papers[6] to critically appraise the concept of climate policy backlash and its use. Our goals were: (i) assess variation in how climate policy backlash is studied, (ii) consolidate insights across fragmented lines of thinking, and (iii) constructively stimulate debate about both the concept and its empirical application in future work. Our approach reflected both a conceptual concern for clarity and a problem-based concern for empirical resonance that is crucial for comparison and integration. We combined a systematic review (to capture heterogeneously distributed literature) with a critical review (to scrutinize papers for fit and meaning against key needs in Section 2.2). This helps to build a rigorous and transparent knowledge base on climate policy backlash to identify insights and research priorities, and future theory-building and testing.

Our search approach included both explicit and implicit links to climate policy backlash.[7] This is important because the term backlash has been used unevenly over time (increasing in recent years). Moreover, not all literature referring to backlash necessarily reflects the concept, while literature that does not use the term may nonetheless reflect the underlying phenomenon. Backlash against any kind of climate-related policy, as well as against seemingly disparate objects such as renewable and non-renewable energy infrastructure, is relevant when considering backlash in any direction (see Introduction).[8] Our approach, therefore, provides a richer scope for identifying relevant work than relying solely on the contingent use of 'backlash' and/or anti-progressive reactions alone.

Our search string combined a trigger-related term (policy or policy-related development) with a reaction-related term (different reactions that could indicate backlash) (Table 1). The trigger-related term focused on climate change mitigation policy. We viewed this in a broad way to allow for backlash against different kinds of climate-related policy, mostly involving pro-climate policy but sometimes also anti-climate policy (such as fossil fuel development). This is important because even espoused climate mitigation policy might become an object of backlash when seen as insufficiently ambitious or due to its multiple meanings/impacts. The reaction-related term focused on three ways in which backlash may be described[9]: (i) backlash itself, (ii) negative policy change,

Table 1. Search string, with the structure: Element 1 (trigger) AND Element 2 (reaction).

Element	Search target	Search string
1. Trigger	Climate change (mitigation) policy*	(climate change OR climate policy OR climate action OR carbon pric* OR carbon tax OR climate law OR climate legisl* OR phase-out OR renewable* OR wind OR solar OR fuel)
2. Reaction	Backlash	(backlash)
	Policy change	(rollback OR repeal OR retrench* OR dismantl*)
	Protest^	(protest* OR dissent OR mobili* OR pushback OR contenti*)

We excluded the term 'carbon market', assuming that 'carbon pric' would also capture relevant papers related to the domestic policy/politics of carbon markets/pricing.

^We excluded several broader terms that would create too many general hits such as 'conflict', 'activism', 'politicisation'/'politicization', 'contested'/'contestation.

and (iii) strong public contestation (all later screened). This captured relevant work across institutionalized and non-institutionalized politics. We conducted separate searches for each reaction term, removing duplicates.

We conducted the search using the database Web of Science (WoS)[10] for all years until 31 December 2024. We screened the papers returned in three steps. First, we filtered the results within WoS by relevant social science fields, leaving this as broad as possible (e.g. environmental studies, political science, public administration, geography, sociology) (Appendix A). We then screened papers based on title and abstract within WoS, excluding those clearly not involving climate change, backlash/ contestation, and/or a plausible connection to our scope. We then closely screened the titles and abstracts of the compiled set in MS Excel, retaining those that focused on climate change mitigation,[11] had substantive attention to backlash/policy change/protest,[12] and focused on domestic policy[13] involving a governmental body (whether national or subnational). This provided the initial coding set.

We then coded the papers in two steps. First, we coded all papers based on title and abstract to assess key attributes and determine specific relevance to climate policy backlash (excluding non-relevant papers sequentially) (Appendix B; Appendix C.1), considering:

(i) Focus and orientation: degree of focus on backlash or related reactions (strong, moderate, weak [exclusion criteria]); use of backlash concept (descriptive, analytical, unclear); overall approach (empirical-observational, empirical-experimental, conceptual, unclear/other);
(ii) Scope: broad object of contention (policy, infrastructure, discourse/debate [exclusion criteria], unclear/other [exclusion criteria]); locus of contestation (national, state/province, local, supranational, unclear/other); backlash orientation (against new policy, against existing policy,[14] both, unclear);
(iii) Policy action: policy mode (hard, mixed, soft, unclear); policy type (regulation, taxes/pricing, phase-outs, other/unclear); policy issue (text); place (text); key actors (text); [exclude if lacking substantive relevance to climate policy backlash].

Second, we coded the entire paper according to our analytical focus (Section 2.2), excluding papers not about climate policy backlash (Appendix C.2), considering:

(i) Plausible presence of backlash (i.e. public contention; abrupt and/or hostile reaction);
(ii) Analytical approaches: object/s; actors; form(s) of backlash; role of subjective perceptions; effects of backlash (policy and political);
(iii) Underlying explanations: reactionary political behavior; interest-based countermobilization; emancipatory political action; 'ordinary' politics.

We retained 671 papers after initial screening, 279 papers after close screening, 142 papers after the first coding round, and 101 papers after final coding (Appendix A; Appendix D). After an additional cross-check using an alternative database (Scopus) we added 3 further papers. This led to a total corpus of 104 papers comprising: 21% ($n_1 = 22$) of papers derived from backlash as reaction term, 23% ($n_2 = 24$) of papers derived from policy change as reaction term, and 56% ($n_3 = 58$) of papers derived from protest as reaction term. Papers concentrated in the period from 2020 onwards, especially those explicitly using the term backlash (Figure 2). Interestingly, the proportion of papers included that specifically mention backlash was relatively low, with papers removed that use the term descriptively rather than analytically or without substantive attention to

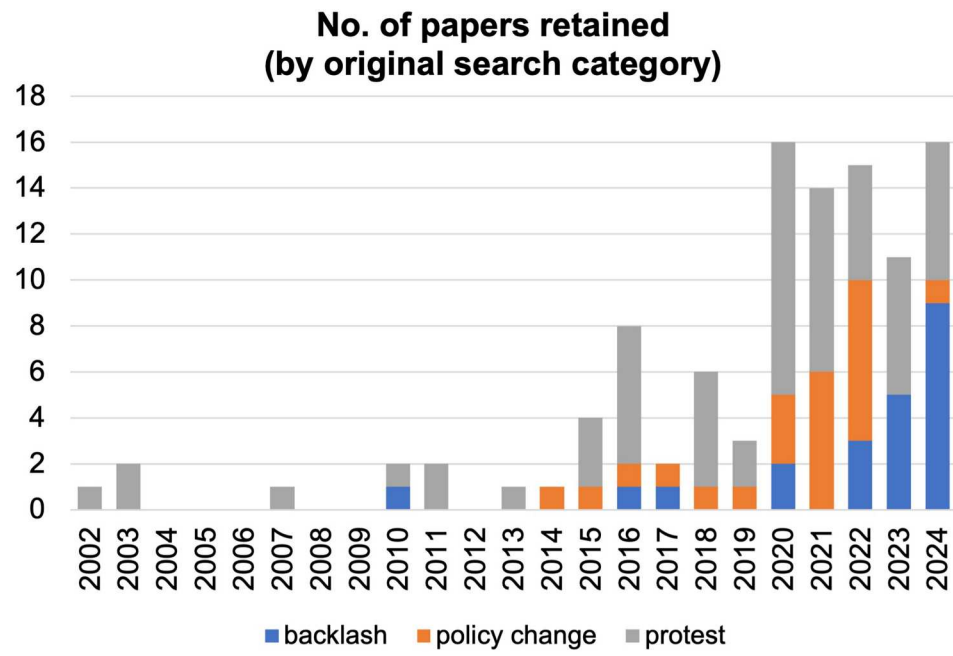


Figure 2. Distribution of papers included over time and by search topic (reaction term).

the phenomenon. This suggests that use of the term backlash does not always correspond to substantive relevance. Hence, when studying climate policy backlash it is important to consider work *not* using this term directly (e.g. work on protest).

4. Varying analytical approaches taken

We now characterize patterns in the papers sampled concerning analytical approaches (i.e. forms of backlash, objects, subjective perceptions, and policy and political effects) (following Section 2.2).

4.1. Forms of backlash and actors involved

Papers involved institutionalized (30%) and non-institutionalized (45%) forms of backlash, and sometimes both together (25%). The form of backlash is moderately associated with the focal level,[15] with institutionalized forms more common in papers focusing at the national and state/province level, and non-institutionalized forms more common in papers focusing at the local level (Appendix E.1). Various actors are involved, including politicians and political parties, mass publics, societal groups (e.g. communities of place/interest, indigenous groups), industry, business associations, labor unions, social welfare associations, and media. We describe forms of backlash and actors broadly based on Patterson's (2023) typology of manifestations of backlash (argumentative, structural, behavioral).

4.1.1. Institutionalized forms

Institutionalized forms of backlash refer to backlash manifesting through formal political channels. Argumentative manifestations especially include negative campaigns by conservative and/or right-

wing populist political actors. For example, fierce campaigning against climate policy by conservative politicians played a central role in driving wider backlash against carbon pricing policy in Australia (Chan, 2015; Crowley, 2017; Patterson & Paterson, 2024). Right-wing populist parties have also campaigned heavily against climate policy in Nordic countries (Finland, Denmark, Sweden) (Arter, 2020; Vihma et al., 2021), and such campaigns weakened mainstream conservative party support for climate policy in the UK (Paterson et al., 2024). Populist far-right parties have also leveraged discontent in regions affected by climate policies in other European countries (Estonia, Germany, Poland), linking it to wider grievances (e.g. migration, national sovereignty) (Yazar & Haarstad, 2023). Some scholars argue that climate policy could increasingly become a wedge issue for right-wing populists to mobilize publics (Dickson & Hobolt, 2025).

Behavioral manifestations of backlash are seen in the political behavior of mass publics and/or elites. For instance, mass public voting has demonstrated pushback against climate policies for wind energy in Ontario (Stokes, 2016) and coal phase-out in the US (Egli et al., 2022), although others have cautioned against generalizing such expectations (Urpelainen & Zhang, 2022). Politicians have used veto powers to block ambitious policy to ban offshore fossil fuel exploration emerging from a citizens' assembly in Ireland (Fitzgerald et al., 2021) and withdrawn electricity market reform for carbon pricing in South Korea due to criticism from ministries, utilities, and industry (Barlaup & Biedenkopf, 2024). Coalitions have formed in criticism of renewable energy policy when it is seen as too costly, such as a coalition of utilities, business associations, politicians, social welfare associations, and a labor union in Germany leading to reduced financial support for renewable energy (Karapin, 2020a), and a coalition of industry and politicians in Denmark leading to a scaling back of climate policy ambition and funding (Eikeland & Inderberg, 2016).

Structural manifestations of backlash are seen in attacks on climate policy and institutions. For instance, an incoming conservative government in Australia repealed carbon pricing policy and attempted to repeal many other elements (policies, agencies, funding) (Chan, 2015; Crowley, 2021, 2017; Patterson & Paterson, 2024). In the US, the first Trump administration rolled back many climate and environmental regulations, withdrew from the Paris Agreement, defunded offices/ agencies, appointed politicized officials, and actively supported fossil fuel expansion (Lin, 2022; Masur, 2022; Mildenberger, 2021; Rios, 2020; Selby, 2019) in a 'pro-fossil fuel backlash' (MacNeil & Paterson, 2020) which is now being repeated in the second Trump administration (Friedman, 2025; Schlanger, 2025). This was echoed in Brazil when the Bolsonaro administration rolled back climate and environmental regulations, disbanded governmental bodies, and limited access to information (Carvalho et al., 2022; Hochstetler, 2021; Toni & Feitosa Chaves, 2022), and earlier in Canada when the Harper government rolled back climate action, muzzled government scientists, and undermined international climate commitments (Lakanen, 2018). At the subnational level, state and provincial governments have also rolled back and criticized climate policy in Ontario, Canada (Raymond, 2020) and several US states (Basseches et al., 2022; Breetz et al., 2018).

Together this shows that even when only considering institutionalized politics, climate policy backlash can manifest in differing ways which may or may not overlap. No single aspect (e.g. argumentation/rhetoric, political behavior, structural attacks) covers the entirety of the concept. Moreover, individual manifestations (e.g. voting behavior) should be examined in connection with their wider political dynamics (e.g. Stokes, 2016). Although this may be widely recognized in principle, there can be a risk of decontextualizing backlash from its political and historical context. At the same time, what exactly backlash involves in each case needs to be made explicit given that it can manifest in different ways and should not be presumed self-evident.

4.1.2. Non-institutionalized forms

Non-institutionalized forms of backlash refer to ways in which backlash manifests outside of existing formal political processes and channels. Argumentative manifestations especially include campaigns involving publics (place-based or interest-based) sometimes also together with elite actors. For example, public campaigns may respond to specific energy infrastructure through protests, petitions, and public submissions, as well as collaboration with political representatives (Anderson & Schirmer, 2015; Bues, 2018), and could also involve small businesses threatened by climate policy (Liu & Chao, 2022). This also reflects structural manifestations of backlash when institutionalized actors become involved, such as broader regional networks joining local campaigns (Moragues-Faus & Ortiz-Miranda, 2010) or large NGOs bringing litigation in support of grassroots campaigns (Chamberlain & Fourie, 2024). Concomitantly, social media might enable discontent to coalesce (e.g. Bendz et al., 2023) or intensify (Fergen et al., 2021) among otherwise disparate actors.

Behavioral manifestations include contentious physical activities, such as protests or demonstrations. For example, contentious place-based activity involving varying coalitions of actors (such as environmentalists, land owners, indigenous groups) has occurred in response to renewable energy infrastructure in many places including against wind energy (Anshelm & Simon, 2016; Arifi & Winkel, 2021; Horsbøl, 2020; Huesca-Pérez et al., 2016; Lindvall, 2023; Lintz & Leibenath, 2020; Rochmińska, 2023; Stokes, 2016), solar energy (Brás et al., 2024; Jacroux & Freshour, 2024; Moore & Hackett, 2016), and electricity grid expansion (Kühne & Weber, 2018). On the other hand, contentious place-based activity involving similar sets of actors has occurred in response to decisions over non-renewable energy linked to climate policy, such as coal power (Arifi & Späth, 2018) and extraction (Delina, 2022), and oil pipelines (Bosworth, 2019; Burrell et al., 2022; Van Neste, 2020). More broadly, contentious responses involving both protest and more generalized discontent have occurred in response to general climate-related policies, such as the massive mobilization of the Yellow Vests in France against carbon pricing seen as unjust (Levain et al., 2022; Martin & Islar, 2021), hostile protests against national carbon pricing policy involving conservative grassroots and political actors in Australia (Copland, 2020; Patterson & Paterson, 2024), pro-diesel protests against restrictions on diesel vehicles in Germany (Arning & Ziefle, 2020), strong discontent over a ban of wood stoves in Sweden (Sahlberg et al., 2022), and physical and online mobilization against mobility policies in cities (Marquet et al., 2025, 2024). Mobilization against the removal of fuel subsidies in Nigeria (Agbonifo, 2023) or imposition of fuel taxes in the UK (Doherty et al., 2002; Robinson, 2003) have even involved blockades of national fuel production or distribution to gain political attention.

At the same time, behavioral manifestations of backlash can lead to counter-responses influencing the dynamics and wider perceptions of backlash. For instance, grassroots pushback against pipelines in North America through campaigning, knowledge building, and direct resistance faced counter-responses involving police and campaigns to portray protestors as violent to undermine public support (Bosworth, 2019; Burrell et al., 2022; Van Neste, 2020). Grassroots groups mobilizing against coal mining expansion have also been labeled as extremist by government in the Czech Republic (Černoch et al., 2019). More broadly, the Yellow Vests protests in France were notable not only for their scale of mobilization and disruption but also for the violent responses of, and clashes with, police (Martin & Islar, 2021). Such manifestations of backlash are therefore inherently dynamic.

Together this reveals how non-institutionalized manifestations of backlash can be both intensively focused (such as on a specific infrastructural development or policy measure) but also broad in how they interact with, and are embedded within, wider social, cultural, and political

contexts. Diverse non-institutionalized manifestations of backlash are within the concept of climate policy backlash but lend a different flavor to the concept compared to institutionalized manifestations. Although, it may not always be possible to clearly separate institutionalized and non-institutionalized manifestations of backlash, especially in contemporary politics where societal discontent and unrest is increasingly bound up with formal political processes, and vice versa.

4.1.3. Overlapping institutionalized and non-institutionalized forms

Overlap of institutionalized and non-institutionalized forms of backlash was sometimes foregrounded. For example, responses to energy infrastructure developments may involve expressions of strong discontent through both public contention (e.g. protests, blockades, campaigns, disruption) and via formal procedures (e.g. public hearings, submissions, review processes, litigation). This includes backlash against pipelines (Bosworth, 2019; Burrell et al., 2022; Hess, 2023; Sveinsdóttir & Johnson, 2023), mining (Anshelm & Haikola, 2018; Silva & Sareen, 2023), wind energy (González et al., 2016; Lindvall, 2023; Moragues-Faus & Ortiz-Miranda, 2010; Ogilvie & Rootes, 2015; Rochmińska, 2023; Stokes et al., 2023), and solar energy (Brás et al., 2024; Hess, 2016; Jacroux & Freshour, 2024). It is also seen in backlash against broader policies such as carbon pricing in Australia which saw hostile pushback in political debates, among publics, and in media (Copland, 2020; Crowley, 2017; Patterson & Paterson, 2024) and similarly in British Columbia, Canada and in California – where the latter even saw a bottom-up ballot proposition (attempting to suspend the law) (Karapin, 2020b). In Los Angeles, a proposed municipal-level green new deal focusing on renewable energy was 'heavily opposed' by the main labor union for municipal workers who even 'funded anti-decarbonization political candidates' (Furnaro & Kay, 2022).

Thus, institutionalized and non-institutionalized manifestations of backlash may appear in varying combinations and should be jointly accommodated. Even when focusing on specific manifestations (e.g. protests, voting behavior), others may also be present. Recognizing that backlash is linked to wider socio-political dynamics is also crucial.

4.2. Objects of backlash and the role of subjective perceptions

The central object of backlash was policy (70%), with the remaining papers focusing on infrastructure (30%). The backlash object is strongly associated with the papers' focal level, with policy more common in papers focusing at the national and state/province level, and infrastructure more common in studies focusing at the local level[16] (Appendix E.2). Of papers with policy as a central object, 29% concerned taxes/pricing, 14% concerned regulation, 10% concerned phase-outs, and 48% concerned a combination of policy types. However, policy type is not significantly associated with the focal level[17] or with the form of backlash[18] (Appendix E.3). Varying reasons for negative perceptions over these objects were identified including: costs (to people, businesses, or the overall economy); political-ideological affinity; anti-elite or anti-mainstream stances; sense of stigmatization of certain technologies and/or practices, disempowerment and/or unfairness in political decision-making; place attachment and impacts on place; and criticisms of political-economic. We now describe these objects and their associated (negative) subjective perceptions.

4.2.1. Policy-related objects

Taxation/pricing policies facing backlash mostly involved economy-wide measures such as emissions trading and carbon prices/taxes. Perceptions of unfairness and disproportionate economic

burden (generally and for specific groups) were common. For example, in California, conservative opponents saw emissions trading as harmful to business or even as an illegal tax (Karapin, 2020b), and some progressive opponents also saw it as a threat to structurally disadvantaged communities (London et al., 2013). The Yellow Vests movement viewed carbon taxes as unfair to people in rural and peri-urban areas and also mobilized anti-elitism, disempowerment, and broader economic criticism (Levain et al., 2022; Martin & Islar, 2021). Backlash to British Columbia's carbon tax involved general economic concerns and perceptions of unfairness to people in rural areas (Beck et al., 2016), yet tax credits aiming to provide compensation backfired by making the tax more visible (Karapin, 2020b, p. 154). In Ontario, economic concerns over carbon pricing reflected anti-elitism and conservative political-ideology mobilized in a populist manner (Raymond, 2020). Similarly, in Australia, economic criticism combined with conservative political-ideology generated public hostility to carbon pricing (Copland, 2020; Crowley, 2021, 2017). In Norway, backlash to road tolls was also linked to populism and anti-elitism (Aasen & Sælen, 2022). Thus, taxation/pricing policies seem especially prone to becoming sources of economic and cultural discontent.

Regulatory policies facing backlash involved mandatory targets and renewable energy standards, sometimes linked to pricing measures such as subsidies or feed-in tariffs. For example, support for renewable energy policy (involving regulation, subsidies, and taxes) was significantly undermined in Denmark during the early/mid-2000s due to the economically liberal political ideology and climate skepticism of an incoming government (Eikeland & Inderberg, 2016). Hostility to renewable energy feed-in tariffs was also expected from an incoming government in Germany in 2010–2011, but this did not arise due to global events that recast renewable energy as domestically necessary (Huß, 2014). Yet, by 2013–2014, rising household costs and fears about industry impacts led to a scaling back of policy support for renewables (Karapin, 2020a). Renewable energy policy was also weakened in Australia in 2013–2014 by an incoming conservative government hostile to climate action, despite being widely favorable among the public (Patterson & Paterson, 2024). Elsewhere, several US states weakened or withdrew support for renewables when energy transition became perceived as an economic threat to incumbent energy producers and utilities (Breetz et al., 2018; Hess, 2016). Thus, backlash to regulatory policies may occur within longer-term political struggles which reshape perceptions among politicians and publics in different ways over time.

Phase-out policies facing backlash involved both fossil fuel production and specific behaviors and technologies. For example, policies targeting fossil fuel production were perceived as an economic, energy security, and cultural threat in Poland (Brauers & Oei, 2020) and a threat to jobs in the United States (Egli et al., 2022). However, such responses may also be embedded within longer-term struggles over the meaning of fossil fuel production within a society (Černoch et al., 2019; Isoaho & Markard, 2020). Phase-out policies targeting behaviors and technologies include planned diesel driving bans in Germany, which were perceived as stigmatizing vehicle owners (Arning & Ziefle, 2020), and the planned phase-out of gasoline scooters and vehicles in Taiwan, which was perceived as unjust (Liu & Chao, 2022). Backlash to a ban on polluting cars in Milan, Italy, increased the likelihood that uncompensated individuals would vote for a radical right party (Colantone et al., 2023), implying that economic measures could at least sometimes help to mitigate backlash. Conversely, the phase-out of wood stoves for home heating in Sweden was perceived as causing a loss of valued traditions (Sahlberg et al., 2022), which is not readily compensable. Thus, negative reactions to phase-out policies might also be both economically and culturally complex due to interconnections with peoples' everyday lives and identities.

Broader climate policies and agendas may also experience backlash. Perhaps most infamously, the anti-climate actions of the first Trump administration (Lin, 2022; MacNeil & Paterson, 2020; Masur, 2022; Mildenberger, 2021; Rios, 2020; Selby, 2019) reflected anti-progressive cultural discontent, endemic fossil fuel industry lobbying, and climate policy counter-movements (Basseches et al., 2022; McCright & Dunlap, 2003). Similarly, the Bolsonaro administration mobilized anti-environmental and anti-cosmopolitan sentiments when dismantling climate and environmental policies in Brazil, perceiving them as threats to economic competitiveness (especially rural industries) and national sovereignty (Hochstetler, 2021; Toni & Feitosa Chaves, 2022). This resembles claims behind hostile opposition, policy rollback, and antagonism towards national and international climate policy by Canada's Harper government (2006–2015) (Lakanen, 2018). As mentioned, right-wing populist parties have also sought to portray climate policy in negative and hostile ways in several European countries (Arter, 2020; Vihma et al., 2021; Yazar & Haarstad, 2023), and in the UK such sentiments arose within the mainstream conservative party despite their longstanding support for climate policy (Paterson et al., 2024). Hence, divided perceptions of climate policy among publics and elites may be entrenched and fluctuate in dominance but also shift in new ways.

4.2.2. Infrastructure-related objects

Renewable energy infrastructure has faced backlash including wind, solar, and power grids. Wind energy was perceived as threatening place-related values such as forests (Arifi & Winkel, 2021), livelihoods (Brown, 2011), landscapes and wildlife (Bues, 2018; Horsbøl, 2020; Lintz & Leibenath, 2020; Moragues-Faus & Ortiz-Miranda, 2010; Ogilvie & Rootes, 2015; Otteni & Weisskircher, 2022; Rochmińska, 2023), and Indigenous values (Huesca-Pérez et al., 2016); and as situations of unequal participation and power in decision-making (Anshelm & Simon, 2016; Bout et al., 2021; Bues, 2018; González et al., 2016; Huesca-Pérez et al., 2016; Songsore et al., 2018; Stokes, 2016) and/or unjust (Anshelm & Simon, 2016; Bues, 2018; Huesca-Pérez et al., 2016; Lindvall, 2023; Stokes et al., 2023). Similar perceptions arose for other infrastructure, such as solar (Brás et al., 2024; Jacroux & Freshour, 2024; Moore & Hackett, 2016), and power grids (Kühne & Weber, 2018). Critical minerals mining for energy transition was a potential backlash object in Portugal although criticism has so far focused on protecting conservation areas rather than opposing extraction (Silva & Sareen, 2023). In Turkey, farmers and other local actors resisted geothermal energy not only due to fear of environmental damage and dispossession, and lack of trust, but also as it was perceived to symbolize authoritarian resource politics (Ozen, 2024).

Fossil fuel infrastructure also faced backlash. This included power plants (Anderson & Schirmer, 2015) and national fossil fuel development (Arifi & Späth, 2018; Chamberlain & Fourie, 2024) including in response to pro-coal advocacy (Delina, 2022). Yet, local communities rejected outside opponents of fossil fuel development when seen as misaligned with local concerns (Colvin, 2020). Pipelines can be perceived in multiple ways as matters of sovereignty, property and natural resource protection, risks to landscapes, and threats to democratic processes and justice (Hess, 2023). Perceptions of pipelines may also be reshaped through deliberate activities such as building counter-expertise (Bosworth, 2019), politicizing regulatory approvals (Sveinsdóttir & Johnson, 2023), asserting overlooked place identities (Van Neste, 2020), and challenging the cultural authority of fossil fuels (Burrell et al., 2022).

Altogether, insights on backlash to infrastructure-related objects suggests that such objects can mean very different things in different contexts. Actors at different levels may also perceive objects

differently. The presence of conflicting perceptions of infrastructural objects therefore problematizes 'the legitimate object of environmental protection' (Arifi & Winkel, 2021, p. 811).

4.3 Policy and political effects of backlash

The policy and political effects of backlash were difficult to systematically characterize because of wide variation in attention.[19] Policy effects included: rollback/reversal (19%), weakening (e.g. deferral of action, reduced stringency) (24%), no change (8%), strengthening (3%), and a combination (24%), with the rest remaining unclear (23%). Broader political effects (often involving several) included: undermining of policy proponents (25%), undermining of broader policy agendas (71%), undermining of institutions (31%), and social and/or political polarization (20%).

4.3.1. Policy effects

Policy rollback/reversal sometimes followed backlash. For instance, in Ontario, a policy aiming to accelerate wind energy was rolled back following community protests and negative voting, effectively blocking wind farm development (Stokes, 2016). Later, a negative populist-style campaign led to a change of government after which the province's cap-and-trade system was repealed (Raymond, 2020). Similarly in Australia, backlash against carbon pricing led to a change of government, the repeal of carbon pricing and targeting of several other policy elements and agencies for removal (Chan, 2015; Copland, 2020; Crowley, 2021, 2017; Patterson & Paterson, 2024). A scheduled carbon tax increase was halted in response to the Yellow Vests protests in France (Levain et al., 2022; Martin & Islar, 2021), and an attempt to remove a fuel subsidy was reversed following mass protests in Nigeria (Agbonifo, 2023). A climate emergency bill banning offshore fossil fuel exploration was blocked by Ireland's minority government using a finance-related veto (Fitzgerald et al., 2021). A ban on wood stoves in homes was reversed in Sweden following widespread discontent (Sahlberg et al., 2022) and a policy aiming to phase out gasoline scooters and vehicles in Taiwan was reversed following fierce pushback (Liu & Chao, 2022). Conversely, attempts to roll back climate policy have themselves experienced backlash from actors seeking to retain climate policy or ambition in Germany (Huß, 2014) and Denmark (Eikeland & Inderberg, 2016). Fierce pro-coal lobbying provoked backlash against coal expansion, leading to a provincial ban on coal in the Philippines (Delina, 2022), and proposed policies aimed at supporting coal mining were partly reversed due to strong grassroots pushback in the Czech Republic (Černoch et al., 2019).

Sometimes, policies were not fully rolled back but nonetheless weakened following backlash. For example, South Korea introduced compensation mechanisms to offset the effect of emissions trading on electricity prices due to pushback among ministries and utilities (Barlaup & Biedenkopf, 2024). Several US states weakened renewable energy policies (e.g. renewable portfolio standards, subsidies), when incumbent utilities and producers perceived renewables uptake as threatening (Breetz et al., 2018; Hess, 2016). Policy weakening also occurred when the infrastructure that it was aimed at supporting was challenged. In Poland, wind energy policy was amended to give municipalities greater planning power over wind energy development as a compromise with opponents (Rochmińska, 2023). In Ontario, Canada, anti-wind citizens' groups challenged a provincial wind energy policy, leading to reduced support for large projects, a greater municipal role, and then limits on overall wind energy expansion (Bues, 2018). More indirectly, González et al. (2016) argue that wind energy planning in Ireland deliberately 'avoided greater centralised coordination' to circumvent anticipated backlash, which led to fragmentation and slower wind uptake.

Occasionally, no apparent policy change or even slight improvement followed backlash. Despite concessions (via a rural tax credit), British Columbia's carbon tax remained unchanged (Beck et al., 2016; Karapin, 2020b). Likewise, the overall market logic of a cap-and-trade scheme remained in California despite a highly critical legal challenge from a formal environmental justice advisory body (London et al., 2013) and subsequent bottom-up referendum (defeated by voters) (Karapin, 2020b; London et al., 2013). In the United Kingdom, pushback against coal phase-out ultimately collapsed (Isoaho & Markard, 2020). In Finland, despite strong pushback against climate policy from a right-wing populist party, the governing coalition (which excluded that party) subsequently took further steps on climate action. More broadly, Urpelainen and Zhang (2022) observe that wind energy projects are most often electorally beneficial in the United States. Altogether, this suggests that certain conditions can lead to climate policy sometimes enduring or even strengthening following backlash.

4.3.2. Political effects

Political effects of backlash were under-elucidated but sometimes observed or implied. First, backlash can undermine the credibility of policy proponents if they were seen to be imposing costly, unfair, or unjustified policies on certain groups or broader society, as in Australia (Copland, 2020; Patterson & Paterson, 2024), France (Martin & Islar, 2021), and Ontario (Raymond, 2020). However, this is not always the case. In the US, oscillation on national climate policy (where new administrations reverse the policy of their predecessor) may provide motivation to both proponents and opponents, rather than necessarily undermining one sides' credibility (e.g. Mildenberger, 2021).

Backlash can also undermine a broader climate policy agenda and associated institutions. For example, the discontinuation of Ontario's feed-in tariff foreshadowed a broader slowdown of wind energy support (Bues, 2018). Australia's carbon pricing repeal was followed by a major and persistent curbing of national climate policy, including attempts to dismantle institutional arrangements, agencies, and climate policy funding (Crowley, 2021; Patterson & Paterson, 2024). Following the Yellow Vests protests in France, the planned fuel tax increase was frozen, casting doubt over the direction of future climate policy (Levain et al., 2022; Martin & Islar, 2021). In Arizona, solar energy opponents were elected to the state utility oversight commission in the midst of pushback and successfully pursued policy changes (eliminating subsidies, creating new charges) that increased the cost of solar (Breetz et al., 2018). In Los Angeles, the municipal workers' union succeeded in getting a city councilor elected who opposed the city's decarbonization plans and sought to delay solar investment (Furnaro & Kay, 2022). In the United Kingdom, the conservative government weakened its own long-championed climate commitments (Bloomfield & Steward, 2024; Paterson et al., 2024). Climate policy rollbacks in the United States (Lin, 2022; MacNeil & Paterson, 2020; Masur, 2022; Mildenberger, 2021; Rios, 2020; Selby, 2019) and Brazil (Hochstetler, 2021; Toni & Feitosa Chaves, 2022) were also accompanied by wider attacks on institutions such as dismantling/defunding agencies and bodies, withdrawing international commitments, withholding knowledge, and shifting priority towards fossil fuel development.

Lastly, backlash may sometimes reinforce socio-political polarization. For example, protests against diesel driving bans likely increased support for the far-right AfD party in Germany (Arning & Ziefle, 2020). Entrenched polarization over wind farms in Sweden (Lindvall, 2023) suggests that individual controversies may reinforce wider patterns, and wind development in Germany tended to strengthen electoral support for both opponents and supporters (Otteni & Weisskircher, 2022). More broadly, longstanding polarization over climate action in the United States (McCright &

Dunlap, 2003) has become linked to nationalist and masculinist worldviews (Selby, 2019), reinforcing divides. Populist parties may also seek to benefit from divides over climate policy (Dickson & Hobolt, 2025; Vihma et al., 2021). Thus, polarization may be both a cause and consequence of backlash.

5. Underlying explanations

The work surveyed in section 4 reveals several underlying explanations for climate policy backlash.[20] This includes seeing backlash as: (i) reactionary political behavior (34%), (ii) interest-based countermobilization (45%), (iii) counter-conduct (22%), or (iv) 'ordinary' politics (11%) (NB: some papers spanned multiple categories). The first two explanations are most common, and the latter two are less so. These explanations help to place climate policy backlash in a wider theoretical frame.

5.1. Reactionary political behavior

Viewing backlash as reactionary political behavior – a reactive pushback to maintain a perceived status quo, often associated with cultural criticism and/or opposition to progressive change – is widespread especially when backlash is linked to right-wing populism. For example, some authors positioned climate policy backlash directly as a right-wing populist phenomenon, motivated by anti-elitism, climate denialism, traditional norms and identities, and nationalism (Vihma et al., 2021; Yazar, 2024; Yazar & Haarstad, 2023). In the UK pushback against net-zero policies was viewed as a populist backlash (Bloomfield & Steward, 2024; Paterson et al., 2024), and Brazil's dismantling of climate-related policy was viewed as a broader pushback driven by far-right populist ideology (Carvalho et al., 2022; Toni & Feitosa Chaves, 2022). In Germany, Otteni and Weisskircher (2022) suggested that constructing wind turbines increased support for AfD (the radical right party) due to their ideological rejection of climate policies and elite opinion. Yet, numerous papers also highlighted the overlap of more pedestrian conservativism, climate skepticism, and political advantage, alongside cultural discontent over progressive policies perceived as threatening economic competitiveness and national good. For example, this was highlighted in Australia (Chan, 2015; Copland, 2020; Crowley, 2017; Patterson & Paterson, 2024), the US (Lin, 2022; Mildenberger, 2021; Rios, 2020; Selby, 2019), and Canada (Lakanen, 2018; Raymond, 2020). At a more local level, Aasen and Sælen (2022) argued that backlash to a road toll in Norway involved an anti-elitist struggle against climate policy, while Stokes et al. (2023) argued that most local pushback against wind farms in North America comes from wealthier and whiter communities implying reactionary opposition. Overall, this view primarily casts backlash as cultural struggle over policy and societal change, even when alongside economic issues that may also motivate cultural criticism. This helpfully situates backlash within a wider social, cultural, and political frame but also risks simplifying it into a pre-defined narrative, homogenizing diverse actor motivations, and portraying backlash as (usually) regressive.

5.2. Interest-based countermobilization

Viewing backlash as interest-based countermobilization – an assertive pushback to defend interests within a set of opportunity structures, often strategic and/or coalitional in character – is also widespread. This view is particularly seen when backlash is linked to material interests and

opportunities. Economic interests drove pushback by government agencies and utilities against emission trading in South Korea (Barlaup & Biedenkopf, 2024), the parliamentary veto of a proposed fossil fuel exploration ban in Ireland (Fitzgerald et al., 2021), pushback against renewable energy policy by incumbent energy utilities and legislatures in several US states (Breetz et al., 2018; Hess, 2016), and parliamentary weakening of renewable energy supports in Germany (Karapin, 2020a). Concerns about interest-based countermobilization were also reflected in policymakers' efforts to avoid backlash among rural residents British Columbia's carbon tax (Beck et al., 2016; Karapin, 2020b) and scholars' attempts to understand whether political institutions and compensation shield governments from backlash against policy with economic consequences (Drake & Skovgaard, 2024). The prominent role of economic interests and political opportunities (e.g. for mobilizing voters) in Australia (Chan, 2015; Crowley, 2017; Patterson & Paterson, 2024), the US (Lin, 2022; Masur, 2022; Mildenberger, 2021; Rios, 2020; Selby, 2019), Canada (Lakanen, 2018; Raymond, 2020), and Brazil (Hochstetler, 2021) also suggests that interest-based countermobilization can occur alongside reactionary political behavior. Interest-based countermobilization is also central to some analyses of public behavior, including pro-diesel protests in Germany driven by personal losses (Arning & Ziefle, 2020), far right voting growth in Milan due to financial impacts of a zoned vehicle ban (Colantone et al., 2023), pushback against scooter and vehicle phase-out in Taiwan due to financial impacts on people and businesses (Liu & Chao, 2022), conservative vote increase in US regions affected by coal job losses (Egli et al., 2022), electoral feedbacks from wind energy development (Urpelainen & Zhang, 2022), and fuel tax protests by affected industries (Doherty et al., 2002; Robinson, 2003) and/or publics (Natalini et al., 2020; Von Uexkull et al., 2024). It is also reflected in another way when positing discontent as linked to economically left-behind rural areas (Rodríguez-Pose & Bartalucci, 2024). Overall, this view helpfully interrogates the material factors motivating backlash, yet risks simplifying it as primarily resource motivated especially if wider issues such as social inequality, political economy, and wider socio-political dynamics are neglected. Interpretive factors (e.g. meanings, emotions) also conditions how interests are understood and may produce non-linear responses, and are thus likely to be crucial alongside interests/resources alone.

5.3. Emancipatory political action

A view of backlash as emancipatory political action – an assertion of political views or interests that are otherwise overlooked and unaccounted for within a policy arena – is sometimes suggested. This is seen in work emphasizing resistance to dominant power relations. It includes, for example, public mobilization to protect local places from renewable energy infrastructure imposed in top-down ways on disadvantaged or marginalized communities (Brás et al., 2024; Brown, 2011; Huesca-Pérez et al., 2016), critical responses to policy believed to accentuate existing patterns of racial/economic discrimination (London et al., 2013), and mass protests against policy change by those who are affected but feel relatively powerless in policy making (Agbonifo, 2023; Levain et al., 2022; Martin & Islar, 2021). Emancipatory political action is also seen in work on counter-conduct.[21] For example, resisting coal mining by advocating alternative energy approaches (Arifi & Späth, 2018), resisting wind farms by articulating alternative objects of concern (Arifi & Winkel, 2021), resisting oil pipelines by generating counter-expertise and new political identities (Bosworth, 2019), and responding to aggressive pro-coal advocacy through anti-coal mobilization (Delina, 2022). Overall, this view opens up a more generative view, where backlash is produced not just as a reaction but as an affirmative development that reshapes political debates and actors involved.

However, it also risks over-valorizing backlash as laudable resistance, potentially simplifying actor motivations, and avoiding difficult questions about prospects for policy action in contested situations.

5.4. 'Ordinary' politics

A view of backlash as 'ordinary' politics – contestation that is seen as a normal development during policy action – is also sometimes suggested. This is seen in work emphasizing planning controversies involving tensions between different actors and scales. For example, contestation over renewable energy infrastructure might arise both when decision-making is devolved (avoiding centralized responsibility) (González et al., 2016) or when it is centralized (generating local pushback) (Bues, 2018), within fractious and evolving negotiations (Kühne & Weber, 2018; Moore & Hackett, 2016), through discontent in planning processes (Rochmińska, 2023), and through clashes between scales (Lindvall, 2023) and forms of knowledge (Anshelm & Simon, 2016). Citizen mobilization against renewable energy infrastructure is not uncommon (Ogilvie & Rootes, 2015; Sovacool et al., 2022), even if socio-economically asymmetric (Stokes et al., 2023), and clashing environmental values produce new forms of conflict over renewable energy (Horsbøl, 2020). More broadly, environmental issues may be readily repoliticized over time (Anshelm & Haikola, 2018), and even dramatic moments of pushback may arise within ongoing, longer-term policy struggles (MacNeil & Paterson, 2020; Patterson & Paterson, 2024). While this may suggest that backlash is *merely* ordinary politics, such a conclusion is too sanguine as it underplays its distinct dynamics, intensity of discontent, and potential impact. Thus, it would be better to say that backlash is distinct *but inseparable from* ordinary politics, reinforcing the need to avoid prematurely limiting its scope.

6. Studying backlash: looking forward

Growing experiences of backlash are confronting climate policy and politics in new ways and receiving increasing scholarly attention. However, the concept of climate policy backlash risks being narrowed in scope, stretched in meaning, and fragmented in emerging lines of thinking. Based on our review, we conclude that current literature provides a rich foundation for studying the demanding concept of climate policy backlash, but it is necessary to do so in a more integrated and explanatory (rather than fragmented and descriptive) way. Three key lessons become apparent: (i) work on institutionalized and non-institutionalized forms of backlash must be linked together, (ii) objects of backlash can vary and must be made explicit while also interrogating (divergent) subjective perceptions of different actors related to these objects to understand why actors respond as they do, and (iii) diverse policy and political effects must be probed to understand why and how different (multi-valent or even contradictory) effects are produced in specific situations.

A pattern running through current work is a tendency to separate analytical categories and even sometimes ignore aspects that do not fit neatly into predefined views about what matters or is worth paying attention to. This is particularly seen in methodologically driven work such as surveys that seem to measure only what can be easily (or already) quantified and can be too quick to make bold claims about what does or does not cause backlash or what should be done in response. But this narrowing tendency can also be reflected in case study work that sometimes puts forward narratives of backlash that are too clean and can lack attention to wider (often messy) sociopolitical processes. What scholars studying climate policy backlash must keep in mind, therefore, is that the phenomenon of backlash is rarely likely to align neatly with typical disciplinary frames, methods, or even

explanatory narratives. Taming its unruly nature in these ways limits the potential for understanding why and how it occurs, and for robust insights into implications and responses.

Climate policy backlash – both as empirical phenomenon and concept – is complex and contradictory. While on first impression it may seem disruptive to policy action and transformation, this becomes more ambiguous on closer examination. Scholars can view backlash as reactionary, interest-driven, emancipatory, ordinary, or perhaps even a combination. Backlash can negatively affect policy and politics (from the standpoint of policy proponents) but could also surface overlooked or marginalized concerns and grievances, and lead to correctives or more representative policymaking. Yet, backlash can also profoundly set back policy action, derail policy agendas, undermine institutions, and reinforce polarization. At the same time, the demarcation of backlash from wider political and contextual dynamics is challenging. Although a single underlying explanation for climate policy backlash may not exist, scholars should be more explicit about their assumptions on this aspect.

It is also crucial to retain an open conception of climate policy backlash that allows it to be studied on in its own terms. The categories applied here help to map out its analytical scope. At minimum, the study of climate policy backlash should be positioned at the interface of institutionalized and non-institutionalized arenas of political activity, as manifestations across both arenas are likely to be common and linked. For example, considering only voting or party politics (as potential institutionalized manifestations) or protests (as a potential non-institutionalized manifestation) alone is unlikely to be enough. Even when specific kinds of manifestations are prominent, the socio-political processes and dynamics producing backlash are likely to be cross-cutting and complex. This also applies to actors involved (which are likely to be multiple and hold diverse perceptions), the objects at stake, and various possible policy and political effects. Resisting undue simplifications (intended or unintended) across these categories is crucial for building a rich understanding of backlash politics, and for integrating insights through transparent points of intellectual exchange.

Studying climate policy backlash requires embracing a relational and contextual approach. Such an approach emphasizes relations between analytical elements situated in their sociopolitical context. Qualitative approaches may seem most immediately applicable, but our prescription certainly does not preclude quantitative methods. What is crucial either way is to give careful attention to socio-political processes and dynamics. It also requires modesty about the limits of inferences drawn from both abstracted studies (e.g. voting behavior, survey experiments) and case study narratives. The focus should be on understanding backlash carefully and critically rather than headline-grabbing claims. Furthermore, important insights can also be gained from work not labeled as backlash, but which illuminates the complex dynamics involved. For example, this includes contentious politics (McAdam et al., 2001), interpretation and emotion in policy struggles (Stone, 2012), and policy contestation and conflict (Weible & Heikkila, 2017; Weible & Sabatier, 2017). This is needed because, after all, backlash is an unruly phenomenon, and we should embrace it on its own unruly terms.

Notes

1. We suggest 'policy backlash' and 'political backlash' are suitable terms because they focus on the dynamics involved rather than specific actors, providing useful boundary concepts.
2. The recent procession of terms includes: climate backlash, climate policy backlash, green backlash, greenlash.
3. And the too simplistic conclusion that varieties of backlash are the reason for observed variation.
4. This challenges survey work on support for climate policy, which sometimes makes inferences about backlash, but is limited because it: (i) often tests hypothetical rather than real-world policy proposals,

(ii) is ex-ante and/or static relative to real-world political debates, and (iii) is methodologically individualist in aggregating individual responses, whereas backlash is generated interactively in dynamic socio-political contexts.

5. For example, Mildenberger et al. (2022) find that partisan messaging can erase people's rational reflection on carbon pricing policy design regarding costs and revenue use.
6. We exclude books which is a limitation of our approach.
7. Explicit = using the term backlash. Implicit = using various alternative terms scrutinized for relevance.
8. We did not systematically review backlash against fossil fuels but remained open where it arose.
9. This did not include specific anti-environmentalism or obstruction terms, which would bring in wider issues, but we assume that policy-specific work from these angles would be captured by the search terms.
10. We use WoS rather than Scopus due to: (i) high levels of overlap, and (ii) despite higher total coverage in Scopus, WoS has stricter quality control. We nonetheless also perform a cross-check with Scopus.
11. Excluding climate adaptation, other environmental topics (e.g., forest or water management), broader topics (e.g., world politics, trade), and different meanings of our search terms.
12. Excluding those that only mention these topics in passing or as motivation for other work (e.g. 'issue X often faces resistance'); and excluding speculative or tangential proposals/arguments.
13. Excluding those primarily focused on other scales (i.e. household, individual, global, transnational); also excluding those focused on general knowledge controversies (e.g., science, denial, scepticism).
14. This allows for backlash against a lack of (or ambiguity over) policy action (e.g., where a policy is not clearly pro- or anti- climate, and/or is considered insufficient or inappropriate by some actors).
15. χ^2 (df: 2, $n = 103$) = 16.47, $p < 0.001$, $V = 0.40$.
16. χ^2 (df: 1, $n = 102$) = 39.60, $p < 0.001$, $\Phi = 0.62$.
17. χ^2 (df: 3, $n = 65$) = 7.25, $p = 0.064$, $V = 0.334$.
18. χ^2 (df: 6, $n = 66$) = 5.45, $p = 0.487$, $V = 0.203$.
19. It is not possible to easily examine associations with other factors (e.g., form of backlash, policy type, level) due to the number of effects and/or overlapping categories. Hence, we only present percentage splits.
20. Similar to section 4.3, it is not possible to easily examine associations with other factors due to overlapping categories, and because these underlying explanations are influenced by (often implicit) decisions of scholars.
21. This refers to: "the will not to be governed thusly, like that, by these people, at this price" (Death, 2010, p. 236, quoting Foucault, 2007, p. 75).

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